

Ad Policing

Reputed firms making false or exaggerated claims about their products in ads are being forced to pull out by the industry's self-regulatory body

■ By Nandini Vaish

The screen opens to a jeep traveling on a lonely forest road. It stops at a rusty ATM called Raju Bank where an old man is sitting on a chair and the 'bank' is actually a dilapidated shack. A foreigner steps out of the jeep and hands his credit card to the old man, who asks him to put his card into a slot in the shanty and punch in the amount. The window reveals another man with his hands bound behind his back. The old man lowers a lever and the man goes ballistic, lapping notes like a dispenser. The foreigner takes his cash and leaves. Cut to the window. There is a Center Fruit candy hanging from the lever. The old man pulls the lever again, and the man stops lapping. It ends with a voiceover that says, "Center Fruit. Kaisi jeebh laplapayee."

This commercial for confectionery maker Perfetti Van Melle was withdrawn because it was deemed offensive. It encouraged "exploitation, abuse of other fellow beings and ill-treatment of compulsive labour," alleged the complaint. Similarly, in January, a television ad by Haier Appliances had to be modified as it claimed "51 per cent power saving", "superior air-conditioning", "intelligent air flow" amongst others.

But Perfetti and Haier are not alone. Procter & Gamble (P&G) was forced to withdraw its ad for Head & Shoulders Intensive Solutions that claimed "seven out of every 10 dermatologists would recommend" the product. These ads, issued by some of the country's biggest advertisers, were forced to amend or withdraw as they either offended sensibilities or could not validate their claims. Enter the Advertising Standards Council of India



ERRING COMMERCIALS

VIDEOCON

PRODUCT: Washing machines

COMPLAINT: The ad showed some boys putting a traffic policeman in the washing machine. The complaint said that any act against a government official is a criminal offence.

ASCI VERDICT: **Ad modified**

HINDUSTAN UNILEVER

PRODUCT: Moo snacks

COMPLAINT: Claim needs to be substantiated with independent data. Advertiser should prove that 'Moo' is healthier than all other snacks.

ASCI VERDICT: **Ad discontinued**

DABUR INDIA

PRODUCT: SaniFresh toilet cleaner

COMPLAINT: SaniFresh Thick toilet cleaner projects itself as a 'hair shampoo'. The advertisement is in bad taste and can harm a vulnerable teenager if he accidentally tries

out the product.

ASCI VERDICT: **Ad withdrawn**

PROCTER & GAMBLE HOME PRODUCTS

PRODUCT: Head & Shoulders Intensive Solutions shampoo

COMPLAINT: Claim needs to be substantiated with proof, supporting information, and with details of survey conducted and its results.

ASCI VERDICT: **Ad withdrawn**

HYUNDAI MOTOR INDIA

PRODUCT: Hyundai Verna

COMPLAINT: The ad claims that the diesel variant "CRDI VGT" used in the vehicle has a fuel economy of 32.8 kmpl. The complainant purchased it under the impression that the vehicle will be economical, but he could never get a fuel economy of over 11 kmpl.

ASCI VERDICT: **Ad discontinued**